



RANJAN RAHI

BIHAR

THE BITTER HALF

By Amitabh Srivastava

Back in 2006, Bihar was the first state in India to offer 50 per cent reservation to women in its panchayats and urban local bodies, then considered a major step in women's empowerment. But 16 years after the fact, the state government is now struggling with a concomitant problem—how to eliminate male proxies or the family members who have usurped the role of the elected representative.

In January this year, the Bihar panchayati raj department finally decided to take the bull by the horns, issuing a stern directive against the practice of nominating proxies (usually husband or son) to represent a woman *mukhiya*. "We want to put an end to the practice of the *mukhiyapati* (*mukhiya*'s husband) exercising undue influence on the work of the panchayat. The law has empowered women, but it is our job to ensure that no one else, be it husband or son, assumes this power granted by the people. The practice of *mukhiyapati* must end," says panchayati raj minister from the BJP, Samrat Choudhary. "We will take disciplinary action and lodge FIRs if a woman *mukhiya*'s family member is found officiating in her place."

Women *mukhiyas* like Sushumlata Kushwaha, a 38-year-old who has a master's degree in social work and is in her second term in Davan panchayat in Bhojpur district, have nothing to fear from the government order. From public meetings to interacting with district officials, Kushwaha does it all herself. Her husband Majee Choudhary, a lawyer, stays away.

BIHAR HAS 4,000-ODD WOMEN MUKHIYAS BUT MANY ARE REDUCED TO PLAYING THE ROLE OF A RUBBER STAMP

But women like Kushwaha are in a minority. At Parma panchayat in Nawada district, 110 km south of capital Patna, Ramadhin Chouhan, 38, officiates as the de facto *mukhiya*, as proxy for his octogenarian mother, three-time *mukhiya* Darshania Devi. "I am her authorised representative," says a belligerent Chouhan. "If the government did not want family members to officiate for the women *mukhiyas*, they should have declared this before the panchayat polls." At Rajauli, another panchayat in Nawada district, *mukhiya* Subhadra Devi sits next to husband Vinay Singh, who does all the talking. Singh, a former *mukhiya* himself, offers a strange analogy to justify his involvement in the proceedings—he argues that just as the wife of a President is the first lady, the spouse of a *mukhiya* should be accorded similar